

The Legitimacy of Wartime Emigration: Evidence from a Conjoint Experiment in Ukraine

Author Names

Abstrakt

Why do some citizens support wartime emigration while others oppose it? Wartime emigration activates moral heuristics grounded in perceived vulnerability, civic duty, and merit. These heuristics shape judgments of departure legitimacy, depending on who leaves, why, and under what conditions. Prior research largely focuses on how host-country publics respond to immigrants, leaving open how wartime emigration is judged by those who stay behind. They offer a broader framework for how moral expectations structure emigration decisions during crisis. The legitimacy of exit during armed conflict poses moral and political dilemmas for those who remain: leaving may signal vulnerability and necessity or suggest disloyalty and avoidance of obligation. We field a paired-profile conjoint experiment in a 2023 survey of Ukrainian citizens to examine how the identity and motivations of emigrants shape public evaluations of wartime departure. Respondents evaluated hypothetical profiles on support for departure, perceived right to leave, and preference for government restriction. These outcomes reflect distinct moral intuitions about compassion, entitlement, and obligation. Judgments reflect overlapping heuristics of humanitarian concern, civic obligation, and merit-based recognition. Mothers fleeing bombardment receive strong support, while conscription-age men receive lower support, especially when departure is framed as voluntary. Highly educated or urban profiles elicit ambivalence, as their symbolic contribution to national cohesion may heighten perceptions of loss when they emigrate. These findings show how wartime conditions structure civic expectations

and inform moral assessments of emigration. We argue that such judgments are structured by civic obligation, vulnerability, and perceived necessity. Departures viewed as elective rather than survival-driven provoke sharper moral resistance, particularly when civic expectations of sacrifice remain salient under threat.

Keywords: emigration, wartime attitudes, conjoint experiment, public opinion, Ukraine

A large and growing body of scholarship examines how immigration shapes public attitudes in host countries, with emphasis on individual characteristics, perceived threat, and contextual or elite cues. However, this work primarily speaks to host-country contexts. Since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, more than 6.5 million Ukrainians have fled the country (UNHCR, 2024), making it one of the largest displacement crises in recent history. Yet little is known about how citizens in war-affected states evaluate emigration. We investigate how citizens in Ukraine assess the legitimacy of departure, using this case to examine how national duty and moral reasoning structure public responses to exit under crisis.

While recent scholarship explores immigration responses to the Russo-Ukrainian War, most studies focus on recipient-country perspectives, such as integration, labor markets, and public opinion about refugees (e.g., Moise, 2024; Strzelecki et al., 2021; Pepinsky, 2024). In Poland, for example, the arrival of more than a million refugees has led to measurable increases in housing prices, highlighting how large-scale displacement generates not only symbolic tensions but material pressures on host societies (Gluszak and Trojanek, 2025). In contrast, emigration and the judgments it provokes among those who remain have received far less attention, particularly under conditions of war (Kustov, 2022). This gap is especially striking given longstanding interest in national identity, civic norms, and deservingness in migration studies (e.g., Grande et al., 2019; Michel et al., 2021). We contribute to this literature by investigating how citizens in a war-affected sending country evaluate the legitimacy of emigration. This context enables us to test whether wartime emigration is judged through heuristics of vulnerability, civic duty, and merit. Using a paired-profile conjoint experiment, we show that public judgments vary systematically with profile traits such as gender,

caregiving responsibilities, and reason for departure. Citizens endorse exit when it signals vulnerability but withdraw support when departure appears voluntary or civic obligations are unfulfilled. These evaluations help theorize how wartime conditions recalibrate moral boundaries of civic belonging and reshape the perceived duties of citizenship.

The Moral Politics of Emigration

Public judgments of emigration remain understudied, particularly from the perspective of those who remain. We examine emigration not as a legal entitlement but as a civic act subject to moral interpretation, where judgments hinge on the perceived legitimacy of departure under crisis. While immigration attitudes have been widely studied, research on emigration has primarily addressed economic effects such as remittances and labor loss (Strielkowski and Šperková, 2016; Libanova and Pozniak, 2023), often overlooking how social norms shape perceptions of those who leave. Recent work emphasizes that emigration decisions are often interpreted through frameworks of familial responsibility, national belonging, and moral obligation (Carling, 2008; Drotbohm, 2015; Boccagni, 2017). Emigration is not solely defined by economic or demographic patterns but is also evaluated as a moral act embedded in social relationships and civic expectations, reflecting what van Dalen and Henkens 2008 (2008) term the power-laden and morally coded nature of migratory decisions. Although much of this literature centers on behavioral intentions, it reveals that emigration decisions are routinely interpreted through normative filters of duty, vulnerability, and symbolic membership. We build on this insight by directly analyzing how wartime emigration is morally judged by those who remain, paying particular attention to how identity-based traits condition moral expectations under conditions of national crisis.

Beyond individual-level heuristics, institutional accounts of welfare emphasize that emigration, especially of skilled or working-age individuals, can disrupt intergenerational reciprocity. In many Central and Eastern European contexts, large-scale departure undermines the demographic and fiscal foundations of the welfare state (Bruzelius, 2021). These structural pressures may intensify

public expectations toward those who remain, particularly during wartime, when sentiments of sacrifice and civic contribution are acutely salient (Roos, 2023). Disapproval of departure thus reflects more than emotional discomfort—it signals the belief that certain exits constitute a civic breach with tangible collective costs. Wartime emigration may be interpreted as a failure to fulfill one’s symbolic and functional role within an already strained civic order.

Recent work on intra-EU mobility suggests that emigration may also be judged as a form of civic disengagement, particularly when it appears to substitute for collective struggle or political reform. Kyriazi and Visconti (2023) argue that the right to free movement within the European Union enables “exit without voice,” allowing individuals to withdraw from domestic hardship without confronting its causes. In this light, departure is not merely a personal or economic act but a morally consequential one that may be viewed as evading the duties of democratic participation. Especially in post-socialist societies where solidarity-based welfare regimes are under strain, this interpretation can reinforce moral expectations that individuals remain engaged in national resilience rather than opting out through departure (Frizell et al., 2025).

In regions such as Central and Eastern Europe, where emigration has been substantial, evidence on public opinion is limited but growing. Timofti (2011), for example, finds that Romanian citizens hold complex and ambivalent views of emigrants, admiring their courage and aspirations for self-realization, yet often framing their decisions in terms of financial self-interest and social estrangement. Research on return migration further suggests that life-course factors such as family obligations, job satisfaction, and affective attachment influence how individuals navigate emigration and re-emigration (Czeranowska et al., 2023). Although this work primarily focuses on behavioral intentions, it shows that migration decisions are embedded in relational and emotional logics, including feelings of duty to kin, emotional ties to place, and normative understandings of responsibility. Emerging evidence also suggests that public responses to migration depend not only on personal traits but on the perceived moral necessity of departure. For instance, Sergeeva and Kamalov (2023) show that Ukrainians are more likely to help displaced individuals when flight

is framed as involuntary and linked to violence, rather than when departure appears voluntary or ambiguous. Similarly, Moreira et al. (2025) find that Colombian citizens express stronger support for emigrants' external voting rights when their exit is attributed to coercion or conflict rather than personal advantage. Although these studies analyze different outcomes—ranging from prosocial behavior to political inclusion—they converge on a common moral heuristic: legitimacy hinges on whether departure is seen as coerced or elective. These findings reinforce our argument that war-time emigration is not evaluated in abstract but through moral filters that weigh identity, context, and intent. Our study contributes to this field by analyzing such judgments directly, with attention to how motivations and personal attributes jointly condition perceived moral entitlement to leave.

The association between moral legitimacy and continued civic membership is not confined to crisis settings. In Finland, Himmelroos and Peltoniemi (2021) find that residents are more supportive of emigrants' voting rights when those individuals are perceived as maintaining political engagement or contributing to the state, and less supportive when emigration is seen as a rupture in civic affiliation. Though centered on electoral inclusion, the study reflects a broader pattern: support for transnational rights is conditioned by perceived loyalty, civic contribution, and continued symbolic membership. These findings suggest that perceptions of emigration inform not only affective or moral judgments, but also the scope of legitimate political membership. Governments make similar distinctions: Turcu and Urbatsch (2020) find that European governments are more inclined to extend voting rights to emigrants deemed electorally loyal, suggesting that institutional inclusion abroad is tethered to symbolic and ideological proximity.

Beyond the Nordic context, recent evidence from Central and Eastern Europe shows that emigration is increasingly interpreted through partisan and moral lenses. Lim (2023) shows that in Poland, Romania, and Hungary, citizens assign differential political legitimacy to emigrants based on perceived civic loyalty and ideological alignment. Right-leaning respondents are especially prone to moralize emigration, portraying emigrants as opportunistic or disloyal and rejecting their continued claims to political voice. These patterns suggest that emigration is not only morally evaluated

but also politicized as a symbolic act—dividing publics along ideological lines, as identity and civic loyalty are reframed through moralized boundary-making (Brubaker, 2017). Perceptions of departure legitimacy thus become entangled in broader disputes over who belongs to the national community and who retains the authority to speak for it.

Extending the prior focus on moral necessity and crisis-induced solidarity, this section turns to how emigration is also interpreted as a civic act, implicating duties, loyalties, and symbolic belonging. Throughout this paper, we define civic obligation as the expectation to contribute to collective efforts during crisis; national belonging as symbolic inclusion in the imagined national community; and national cohesion as the perceived unity and durability of that community across time and space. Public attitudes reflect not only compassion for vulnerability but also judgments about civic responsibility and moral membership. Kustov (2022) finds that emigration often provokes unease when it is viewed as an abandonment of collective duty during national crisis. Vink et al. (2019), in their study of Dutch attitudes toward dual citizenship, reveal a striking asymmetry: citizens view dual nationality more favorably for immigrants than for emigrants. This divergence stems from the belief that emigrants sever symbolic ties, whereas immigrants signal entry and commitment. Political elites across Eastern Europe have also framed emigration in moral terms, portraying out-migration as a betrayal of national solidarity or a threat to demographic sustainability (Roos 2023). While distinct from public opinion, these elite discourses mirror the civic logics through which emigration is often morally judged. Bakewell (2010) similarly argues that civic belonging is not merely legal status but a morally encoded relationship to the polity. Lubkemann (2008) shows that emigration can breach obligations embedded in kinship and community. These patterns demonstrate that emigration is not a neutral demographic event but one infused with normative expectations about who remains part of the national moral circle (Fessler et al., 2015).

While this paper focuses on public judgments of emigrants, other research emphasizes that emigrants themselves engage in moral evaluations of prospective host societies. Elinder, Erixson, and Hammar (Forthcoming) find that Ukrainian refugees prioritize safety, democracy, and gender equ-

ality when envisioning ideal destinations, often preferring distant liberal democracies over geographically or culturally proximate states. These preferences reflect more than instrumental reasoning; they convey normative assessments about the political and ethical character of receiving societies, as Elinder, Erixson, and Hammar (2023) show in their analysis of Ukrainian refugees' destination choices. Wartime displacement, in this view, produces not only humanitarian need but also a comparative moral gaze. Legitimacy in wartime emigration thus emerges through a relational moral process: just as publics evaluate those who leave, emigrants themselves morally assess the political character of receiving societies.

Inherited symbolic frames. Florio (2021) adds further nuance to this body of work by showing that regions with a strong historical legacy of emigration exhibit more exclusionary attitudes toward immigrants today. Her findings indicate that past mobility patterns shape collective memory and reinforce symbolic boundaries, producing persistent expectations about who is included and who is morally suspect. Although her study focuses on immigration attitudes, the symbolic boundary logic she documents may extend to how communities perceive those who leave as well. Recent research similarly finds that symbolic traditions and national myths shape civic expectations and moral evaluations of mobility in Ukraine, particularly under conditions of war (Shevel, 2011, 93). Broader comparative work underscores how such symbolic imaginaries shape migration boundaries across Central and Eastern Europe, often rendering emigrants normatively ambiguous (Brubacker et al., 2024). Emigration, too, may activate inherited interpretive frames, especially in settings like Ukraine, where mass mobility is both historic and ongoing. In such contexts, wartime departures may be evaluated not only in terms of civic obligation, but also in relation to these enduring symbolic expectations about national cohesion and belonging.

Together, these studies suggest that public judgments about emigration are shaped by two intersecting moral repertoires: symbolic foundations, rooted in historical memory and collective identity, and situational judgments formed in response to immediate disruptions. Symbolic foundations encompass inherited understandings of civic duty, loyalty, and belonging, often transmitted through

education, political rhetoric, or commemoration practices. These symbolic frames are anchored in long-standing narratives of national virtue and shaped by past experiences of migration, embedded in collective narratives (Florio 2021). Such frameworks shape perceptions of civic loyalty and signal when departure constitutes moral transgression. Situational morality, by contrast, arises under conditions of crisis, where individuals assess others based on perceived necessity, vulnerability, or civic contribution. This distinction parallels migration theories that separate structural embeddedness from agency under crisis (Bakewell 2008; Lubkemann 2008). While symbolic expectations provide enduring moral baselines, situational cues recalibrate them in real time, yielding judgments that are both historically conditioned and contextually responsive. Our framework uses this duality to interpret how citizens may evaluate the legitimacy of emigration during war, distinguishing between inherited symbolic cues (such as narratives of duty, sacrifice, or betrayal) and situational signals of necessity (such as proximity to violence or caregiving burdens). In addition to these symbolic expectations, psychological mechanisms may offer additional insight into how citizens evaluate the civic legitimacy of those who leave.

Beyond inherited symbolic norms and situational cues, elite narratives and state strategies also shape how emigration is morally evaluated. Prior research shows that emigration is not only a demographic or economic process, but a politically meaningful act interpreted through competing visions of civic belonging. Political actors frequently frame emigration as either patriotic contribution or civic abandonment, depending on shifting national priorities (Kyriazi 2021; Chauvet and Mercier 2014; Careja and Emmenegger 2012). In Romania, parliamentary debates portray emigrants as politically consequential figures whose departures symbolize inclusion in or detachment from the national project (Gherghina et al. 2022). These portrayals reflect broader efforts by states to regulate exit through selective tolerance, control over timing and conditions, and the construction of moral hierarchies around contribution and belonging (de Haas and Vezzoli 2011).

While this literature advances understanding of how elites politicize emigration, it centers primarily on institutional discourse and state-level strategies. We extend this perspective by shifting focus

to how ordinary citizens evaluate wartime departure. Our study examines how public judgments reflect normative expectations tied to civic duty, vulnerability, and perceived necessity. In doing so, we treat emigration not merely as an instrument of statecraft, but as a morally contested act shaped by individual traits and crisis conditions.

Blatant dehumanization. Building on normative accounts of obligation and solidarity, Bruneau et al. (2018) show that individuals in several Eastern and Southern European countries who openly deny refugees' full humanity, as measured using the "Ascent of Man" scale (which assesses the extent to which respondents view refugees as less evolved), are significantly more likely to endorse punitive and exclusionary migration policies, including the denial of aid, confinement, and deportation. These associations persist even after accounting for ideology, perceived threat, and general prejudice. Crucially, dehumanization emerges as a distinct psychological mechanism that shapes both attitudinal and behavioral responses, beyond standard models of prejudice. This mechanism is especially relevant in post-Soviet contexts, where national identity is often tied to sacrifice and civic duty. In Ukraine, dehumanizing perceptions may sharpen the moral condemnation of conscription-age male emigrants, casting their departure not only as disloyal, but as a transgression against the collective. Such dynamics deepen judgments about civic legitimacy and deservingness, making these individuals especially vulnerable to categorical exclusion.

Individual-level traits and heuristics. Public judgments about wartime emigration vary systematically with identity-linked attributes, reflecting moral heuristics related to vulnerability, obligation, and contribution. A substantial body of research shows that public support for migrants is shaped by perceived traits such as gender, religion, and occupation, with caregiving roles and forced displacement eliciting higher sympathy than economically motivated migration (Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner 2016; 2023). Letki et al. (2024) extend this framework to the Ukrainian context using profile-based experiments, showing that caregiving mothers fleeing bombardment are viewed as particularly deserving, while conscription-age men receive lower support when their departure appears elective. This reflects a domestic wartime binary between those expected to remain and

serve, and those permitted to leave. Military-age men are implicitly judged not only by risk but by civic obligation, with departure interpreted as a violation of national responsibility. These findings suggest that civic expectations surrounding duty and sacrifice remain salient even under existential threat. Qualitative work by Stoliaryk (2024) reinforces this dynamic by documenting how Ukrainian public narratives invoke gendered norms of care and national responsibility when evaluating who is seen as justified in leaving. Our findings echo these patterns. Profiles marked by higher education or urban origin receive more ambivalent evaluations, indicating that symbolic capital does not reliably generate moral endorsement. These patterns reveal that trait-based appraisals constitute a core mechanism through which citizens navigate wartime emigration, making profile variation a powerful lens for understanding moral judgment during crisis.

Wartime pressure and civic dilemmas. In the Ukrainian context, wartime emigration generates particularly acute moral dilemmas, as citizens must navigate tensions between civic duty, vulnerability, and collective solidarity. Capturing how citizens negotiate these pressures is essential to understanding how war recalibrates collective norms, obligations, and the perceived boundaries of solidarity. Public judgments often hinge on perceived necessity, which reflects a broader moral continuum of legitimacy and deservingness. Stereotypical expectations surrounding vulnerability and civic responsibility, including gendered assumptions, frequently shape these perceptions. Fleeing bombardment or violence is commonly regarded as highly justified, whereas economically or professionally motivated departures are more likely to be viewed as elective and therefore less morally warranted. These distinctions reflect how civic obligation is framed not only in legal terms but also as a normative expectation informed by democratic ideals of public responsibility (Ingesson 2020). Gendered moral expectations further complicate these judgments. Wartime research shows that women's departures are more often interpreted as driven by vulnerability, while men's exits tend to be evaluated in terms of civic duty and avoidance (Schmeidl and Koser 1998; Sjoberg 2009).

This analysis builds on recent work showing that community norms and collective anxieties during

wartime shape how civilians respond to displacement pressures (Kossowska et al. 2023).¹ Systematic assessments of domestic opinion during conflict remain limited, as the extraordinary pace and scale of displacement often exceed the capacity of institutional or academic actors to capture evolving public sentiment. This study contributes new empirical evidence from a context typically overlooked, offering insight into how citizens of a war-affected country assess the legitimacy of exit and the traits that render individuals more or less deserving of departure.

Normative Judgments and Heuristics of Deservingness

Such individual-level judgments also reflect deeper political tensions between exit and loyalty. As Hirschman (1970) argued, exit is not a politically neutral act. It competes with voice and carries implications for collective solidarity, democratic responsiveness, and civic accountability. This logic intensifies under wartime conditions: moral judgments of those who leave often function as affirmations of shared sacrifice and civic commitment among those who stay. These judgments extend beyond individual preferences or intuitive heuristics. They express broader civic commitments and help sustain civic cohesion under threat. Assessments of emigrants do more than interpret behavior. They reaffirm collective norms, delineate the symbolic boundaries of belonging, and help sustain the moral foundations of wartime political order. These civic judgments, in turn, sharpen public questions about who is considered morally justified in leaving during wartime.

Humanitarian Recognition

Who deserves to emigrate during wartime is not simply a legal question; it reflects a layered moral terrain shaped by norms of duty, vulnerability, and perceived contribution. These evaluations are not arbitrary. They follow recurring moral heuristics rooted in how individuals perceive necessity, control, and civic value (Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner, 2016). Research in social cognition shows that individuals form moral evaluations based on perceived traits, especially warmth and

¹For a conceptual account of solidarity practices that move beyond nationalized frameworks of belonging, see Schwietz and Schwenken (2020).

competence, which shape intuitive judgments of worthiness and legitimacy (Fiske et al., 2002; Cuddy et al., 2008). These dimensions align closely with criteria such as control, reciprocity, and need. One influential framework identifies five criteria that guide such moral evaluations: control, attitude, reciprocity, identity, and need (van Oorschot, 2006).

The humanitarian heuristic is anchored in vulnerability, broadly understood as a lack of control over one's circumstances and a high degree of need (van Oorschot, 2006). Individuals perceived as at risk, such as parents with dependents or civilians near active conflict, tend to elicit stronger sympathy and moral recognition. These judgments often reflect perceptions of warmth, a core dimension of the Stereotype Content Model in social psychology, which associates traits like friendliness, sincerity, and trustworthiness with deservingness (Fiske et al., 2002). In wartime, caregiving responsibilities, disability, and proximity to violence increase the salience of these cues, making departure appear less voluntary and more about survival. Experimental research confirms that asylum seekers fleeing violence or caring for children are seen as more deserving of support (Bansak, Hainmueller, and Hangartner, 2016).

We advance a framework of three core moral logics of deservingness: humanitarian protection, civic obligation, and merit-based recognition. Each reflects a distinct evaluative lens through which citizens assess the legitimacy of wartime emigration. These heuristics reflect established findings that public judgments of deservingness are shaped by perceived control, reciprocity, identity, and need (van Oorschot, 2006; Jiménez, 2022; De Coninck and Matthijs, 2023). Particularly in crisis contexts, public discourse frequently invokes binary distinctions such as “refugee” versus “economic migrant” to demarcate who is seen as morally entitled to leave. While these categories are often treated as neutral heuristics, critical scholarship underscores their ideological and racialized foundations. As Paynter (2022) argues, such distinctions obscure the structural conditions that compel mobility and embed exclusionary logics within humanitarian evaluations. Although our study focuses on intra-national public judgments during wartime, this critique remains salient. It reveals how moral heuristics can reproduce existing hierarchies even in settings where race is not

explicitly mobilized. Our analysis builds on this insight by showing how wartime heuristics of humanitarian need, civic duty, and merit draw on similarly simplified moral categorizations, albeit grounded in national rather than racial imaginaries.

Civic Obligation and Merit-Based Recognition

While humanitarian recognition highlights need and limited agency, public assessments of wartime emigration also invoke a distinct set of norms tied to civic responsibility and social contribution. Wartime frequently transforms citizenship into a moral contract in which individuals, especially those perceived as able-bodied and of military age, are expected to fulfill civic obligations (Walzer 1977; Frizell and Muliavka 2025; Sorg, Wagner, and Onderco 2025). Public expectations of service are often tied to attributes such as age, gender, and physical ability, which historically signal eligibility for national sacrifice. These expectations reflect long-standing associations between civic worth and national contribution, particularly during moments of collective threat.

Recent survey evidence shows that proximity to violence increases expectations of civic duty and military participation (Sorg et al. 2025), while wartime solidarity reinforces norms of collective sacrifice and support for welfare redistribution (Frizell and Muliavka 2025). These findings illustrate how wartime reshapes moral evaluations of civic behavior, reinforcing expectations of national loyalty. Judgments of desert in such contexts extend beyond emotional reaction and reflect shared norms surrounding duty, reciprocity, and contribution.

The merit-based or cosmopolitan heuristic evaluates individuals through attributes associated with skill, education, and professional achievement. These traits signal not only elite status but also potential utility abroad, shaping how states and publics interpret emigration. In some cases, migration by highly educated or urban-origin individuals is viewed as an extension of national competence and reputational capital rather than civic abandonment (Walsh and Tartakovsky, 2021; Kustov, 2022). Yet these interpretations remain contested, particularly in contexts where brain drain raises concerns about development and long-term state capacity (Brock, 2016).

Ukraine's experience of direct invasion and compulsory conscription creates sharp tradeoffs between personal safety and civic duty. These conditions elevate the importance of identity-linked traits such as caregiving, gender, and education in shaping public moral judgments. Educational attainment and cultural capital, for instance, may prompt merit-based or cosmopolitan appraisals of legitimacy, though such interpretations are often contested. These tensions show how wartime crises recast emigration not merely as physical departure, but as a morally charged civic act.

Beyond individual judgments, institutional accounts of welfare also highlight the civic loss associated with emigration. In many Central and Eastern European contexts, the large-scale departure of working-age or high-skilled individuals undermines intergenerational reciprocity and strains the demographic foundations of welfare regimes (Bruzelius, 2021). These institutional pressures may sharpen normative expectations placed on those who remain, especially during wartime, when public sentiment is already oriented toward sacrifice and national cohesion. Moral disapproval of departure may thus reflect not only affective reactions to desertion, but also a structural concern with preserving the functional resilience of the polity.

These evaluations reflect more than individual traits; they are embedded in a broader moral climate shaped by wartime civic cohesion. Research by Bezrukova and Vilkova (2025) and Frizzell and Muliavka (2025) documents how the war in Ukraine has activated strong norms of mutual responsibility, framing moral judgment around shared endurance. Extending this insight, we theorize that caregiving profiles will trigger the humanitarian heuristic, signaling vulnerability and sacrifice. In contrast, able-bodied men who depart are likely to activate the civic duty heuristic, where exit is interpreted as a potential breach of obligation. Profiles marked by education or cosmopolitan status often elicit more ambivalent responses, as the merit-based heuristic does not reliably supersede wartime expectations of civic contribution. Rather than treating these heuristics as discrete, we embed them within a broader normative matrix, capturing how war recalibrates the moral economy of emigration. Ukraine presents an especially sharp context in which to observe these dynamics. The war has activated horizontal civic solidarity and compulsory civic obligations, creating visible

tradeoffs between individual safety and national contribution. These conditions sharpen the moral stakes of emigration, recasting departures not merely as personal decisions, but as symbolic acts with civic meaning.

This framework also finds support in comparative evidence. Sorg, Wagner, and Onderco (2025) find that citizens living closer to active conflict exhibit significantly higher willingness to fight, indicating that geographic proximity intensifies civic expectations and moral commitments. Although our analysis centers on Ukraine, this comparative evidence suggests the potential generalizability of wartime civic norms. We revisit this connection in the conclusion.

These patterns reveal that public judgments of wartime emigration are structured by three overlapping moral heuristics. Vulnerability tends to prompt moral approval, abrogation of civic duty may trigger moral condemnation, and merit-linked traits can invite merit-based endorsement. These logics correspond to broader structures of social cognition, including perceived warmth and competence (Fiske et al., 2002), and reflect symbolic expectations about threat, contribution, and solidarity (Walsh and Tartakovsky, 2021). They also echo long-standing theories of civic cohesion and wartime sacrifice (Walzer, 1977). Together, these heuristics clarify how war reshapes the criteria through which emigration is evaluated, not simply as physical movement but as a morally charged civic act.

These heuristics are not discrete. We frame them within a two-dimensional model of moral evaluation that adapts the dimensions of perceived warmth and competence to the civic context of wartime emigration. While the Stereotype Content Model (Fiske et al., 2002) identifies warmth and competence as core dimensions of social cognition, we reinterpret them here to capture moral judgments under crisis. In this context, warmth reflects perceived vulnerability and empathy, whereas civic competence refers to expectations of duty, capacity, and contribution. Together, these dimensions structure how the three heuristics—humanitarian protection, civic obligation, and merit-based recognition—guide public assessments of who deserves to leave.

To test our expectations, we field a paired-profile conjoint experiment in which respondents evaluate hypothetical emigrants who vary in vulnerability, civic obligation, and social status. This design isolates the causal effect of identity-linked traits on legitimacy judgments under wartime conditions.

Gendered Moral Economies of Emigration

Public judgments of wartime emigration are deeply shaped by gendered expectations, which cut across all three deservingness heuristics—humanitarian, civic, and merit-based. Female individuals, especially those with caregiving responsibilities, are often perceived as high in warmth but lower in competence, a configuration linked to benevolent sexism that generates protective responses and moral approval of departure (Glick and Fiske, 2001). These moral allowances are reinforced by wider gender norms that frame women as natural caretakers, a role further emphasized during periods of crisis (Dueck and Weisner, 2023). Our results show that women with children are consistently rated as more deserving of emigration, particularly in contrast to men of military age, who are more frequently evaluated through lenses of competence, civic obligation, and national sacrifice (Eckes, 2002; Glick, Fiske, and Massen, 2004). This divergence reflects not only psychological stereotypes but also legal and institutional constraints, such as Ukraine’s martial law policy that restricts most men from leaving the country (Atamaniuk and Klymenko, 2024). These asymmetries mirror and intensify public expectations about gendered contributions to national resilience. Qualitative evidence from wartime Ukraine suggests that women are often embedded in informal caregiving and volunteer networks, while men are expected to serve in formal military capacities, reinforcing dual normative standards for mobility and civic responsibility (Boichak and McKernan, 2024). Together, these dynamics constitute a gendered moral economy of emigration, where legal structure, social norms, and perceived traits converge to shape public judgments.

We focus on Ukraine because it enables the empirical testing of moral deservingness logics under conditions of mass displacement, gendered civic expectations, and high-stakes national mobili-

zation. Its experience with conscription, wartime displacement, and a strong pro-European civic identity makes it an especially generative case for examining how symbolic and identity-linked traits shape public judgments of emigration.

Empirical Strategy: Conceptual Framework and Design

Conjoint Design and Attribute Operationalization

To test these theoretical expectations, we embedded a paired-profile conjoint experiment in a nationally representative survey conducted in Ukraine. This design allows us to estimate how individual-level traits shape public judgments about the legitimacy of emigration during wartime. The method builds on established applications of conjoint experiments in the study of immigration attitudes (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2014), adapting it to a wartime emigration context. Fielded in 2023, the experiment presented respondents with three randomly paired profile sets, each comprising fully randomized attribute combinations. For each pair, respondents indicated (1) who had a greater right to leave, (2) how much they supported each individual’s departure, and (3) whether the government should have intervened to prevent it. Profiles varied across six randomized attributes: gender, age, education, number of children, oblast of origin, and reason for leaving. Each attribute was selected to operationalize a specific moral heuristic.

Tabul’ka 1: Operationalization of Theoretical Heuristics

Attribute	Levels	Heuristic Activated
Gender	Male / Female	Civic Duty / Humanitarian
Reason for Leaving	Bombardment / Conscription	Necessity / Obligation
Number of Children	0 / 2	Vulnerability / Empathy
Education	Secondary / University	Merit-based / Competence
Oblast	Donbas / Kyiv	Proximity to risk / Identity

Note: Attribute levels represent randomized profile components. Each is theorized to activate one or more heuristic dimensions derived from social psychology and normative theory. Levels shown are representative examples, not exhaustive.

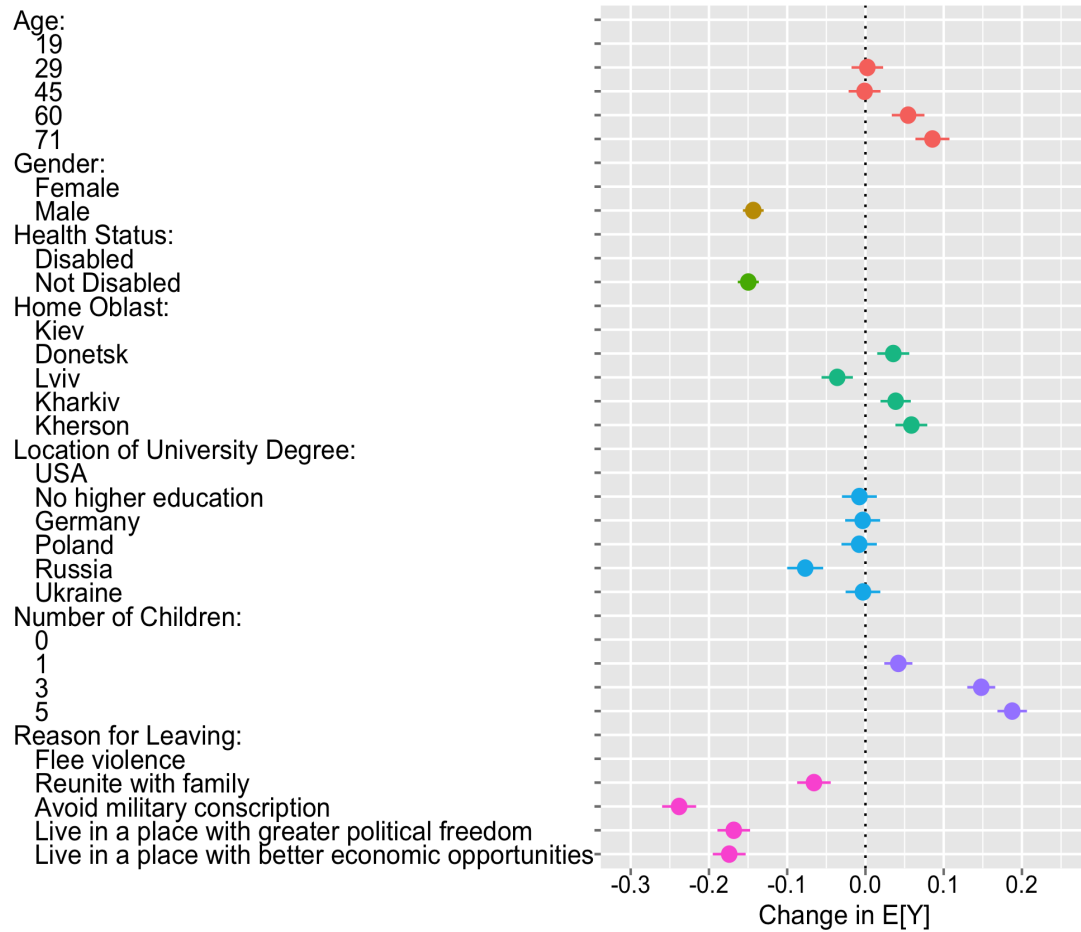
Individual traits further signal the perceived necessity, legitimacy, and morality of departure. Gen-

der, parental status, and health signal vulnerability and caregiving obligations, thereby activating the humanitarian heuristic. Age and gender jointly reflect expectations of civic obligation, particularly under wartime norms that position able-bodied men as morally bound to national defense. Education and urban background cue meritocratic or cosmopolitan logics, linked to perceived cultural affinity or value abroad. These attributes also correspond to publicly salient categories of contribution and need, reflecting scripts of contribution and need shaped by wartime socialization and national policy expectations (Bezrukova and Vilkova, 2025). Their findings suggest that trait evaluations are not insulated from context: rather, wartime stressors can magnify the salience of particular traits—such as gender or reason for departure—by framing them in terms of loyalty or sacrifice (Sergeeva and Kamalov, 2023). The stated reason for emigration, ranging from fleeing bombardment to avoiding conscription, tests whether respondents differentiate between moral necessity and self-interest. In wartime, distinctions between “refugees” and “emigrants” often collapse, rendering public evaluations highly sensitive to perceived necessity, coercion, and moral intent (Betts and Collier, 2017). This design permits causal inference on how citizens in war-affected contexts assign or withhold legitimacy across varied profile types. While our design isolates trait-based effects using randomized conjoint profiles, related panel studies using observational data (e.g., Bezrukova and Vilkova, 2025) show that public solidarity norms evolve dynamically over time, reinforcing the importance of capturing wartime heuristics in real time.

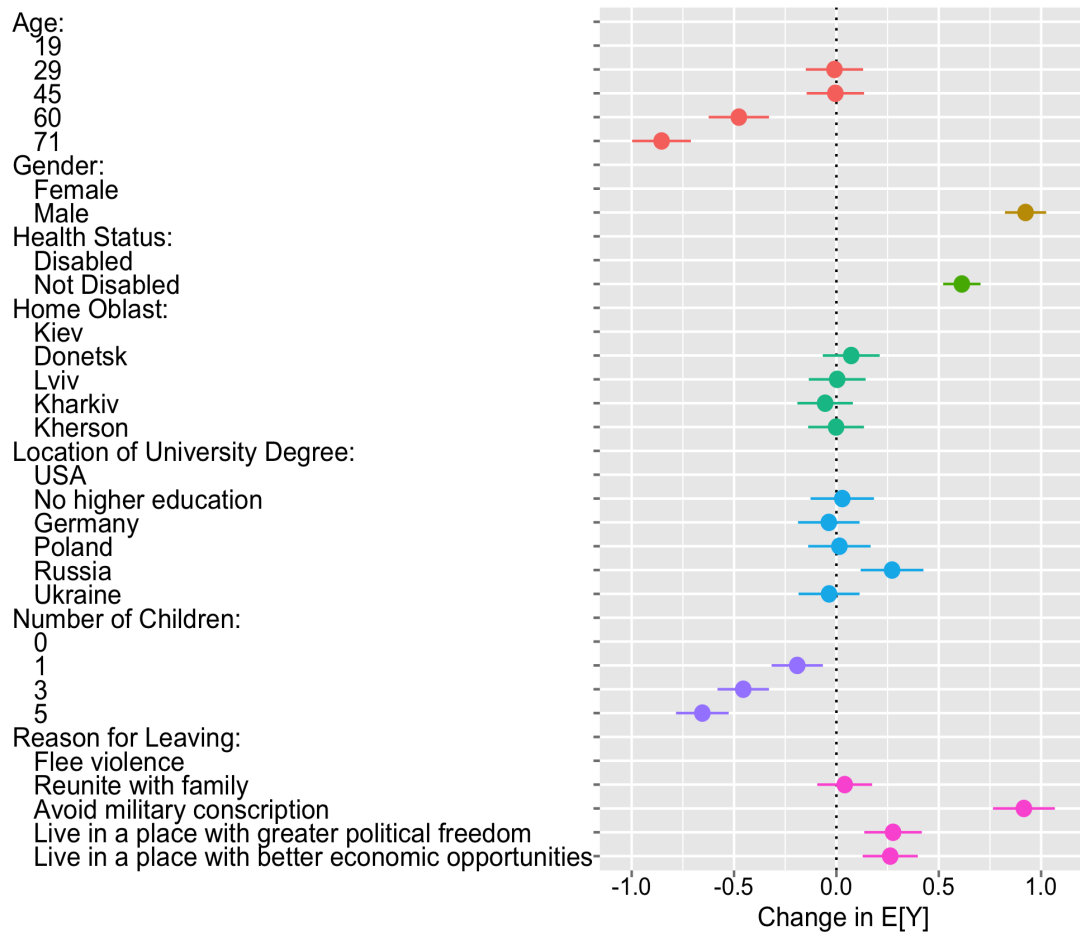
Outcome Measures and Theoretical Mapping

Each outcome measure captures a distinct dimension of how the public morally evaluates emigration under wartime conditions. Support for departure reflects humanitarian concern, identifying individuals perceived as vulnerable or in need of protection. The belief that an individual had a right to leave signals normative judgments about personal autonomy and moral legitimacy. A preference for government restriction reveals expectations of civic obligation and national discipline. Variation across these outcomes and profile traits allows us to test how different deservingness heuristics structure public opinion under conditions of war.

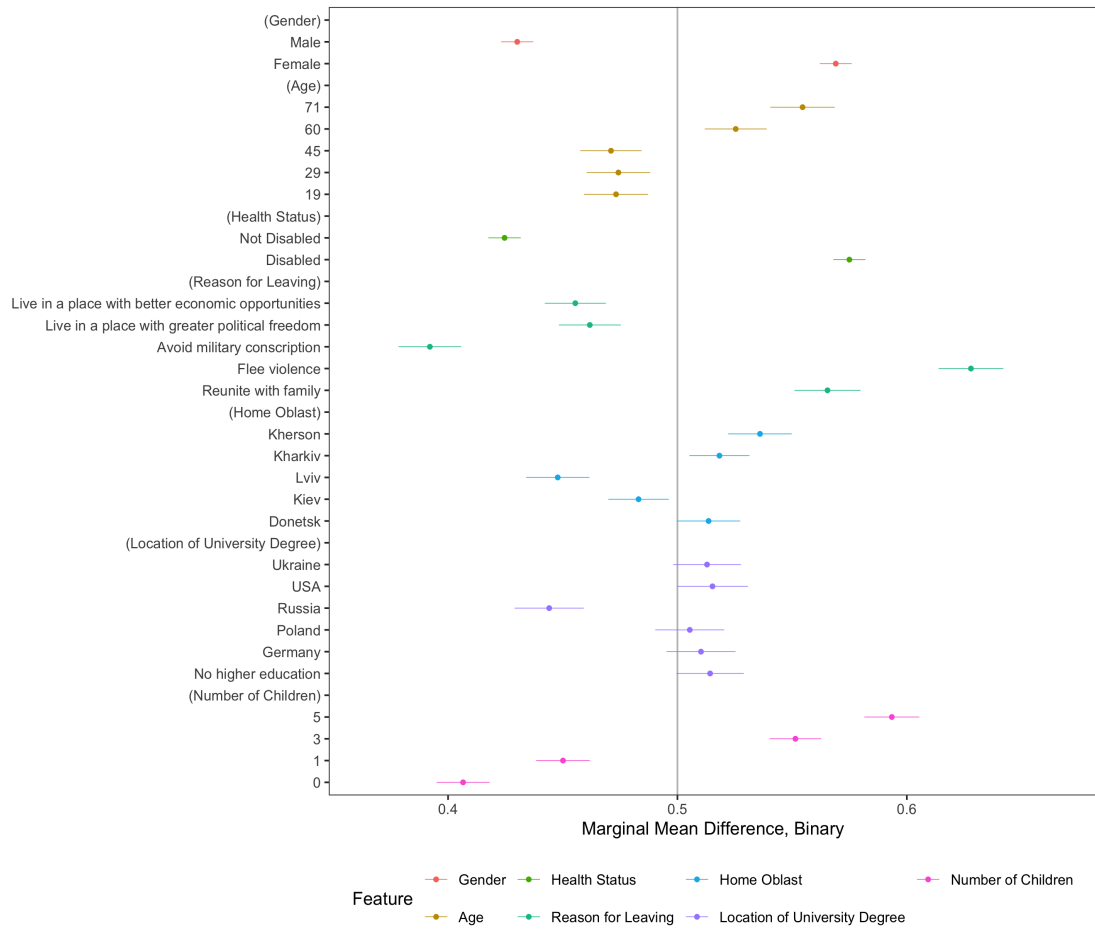
Empirical Analysis



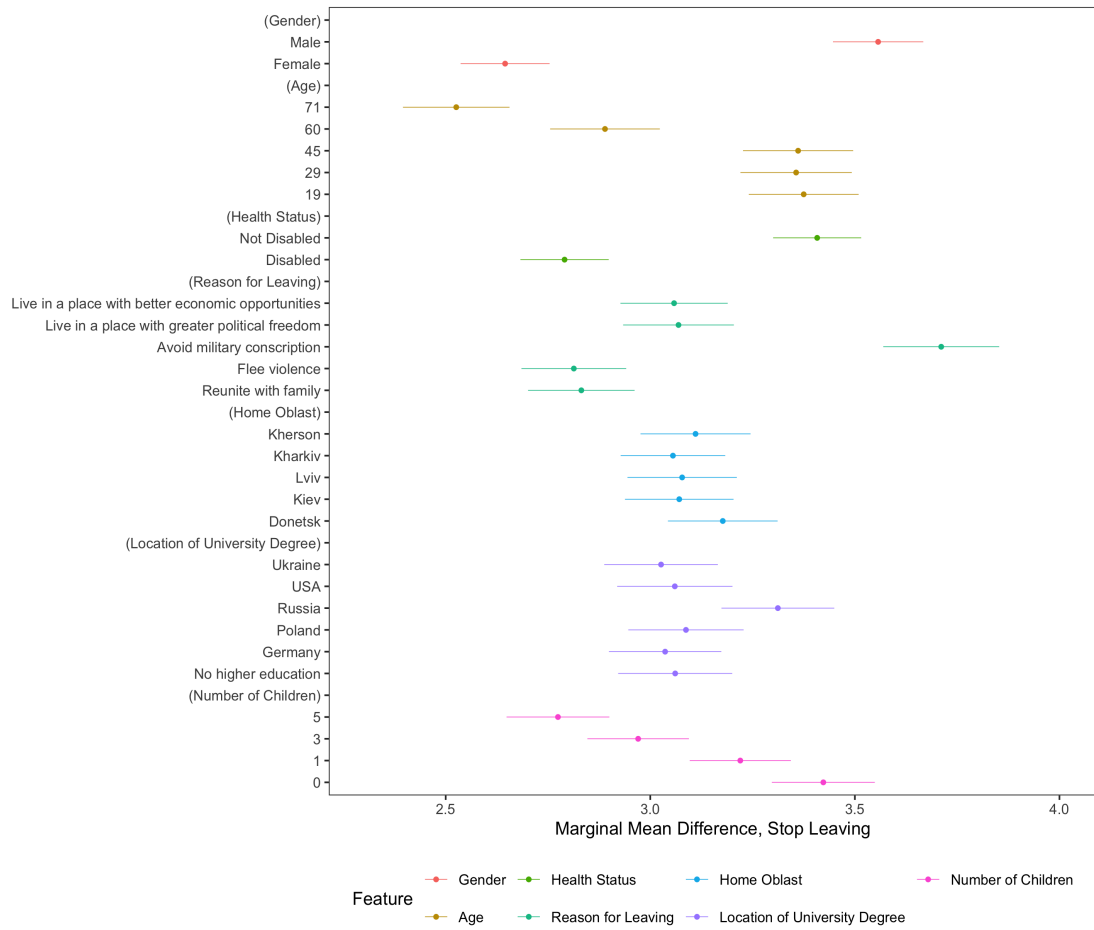
Obr. 1: AMCE (Average Marginal Component Effects) with Forced Choice Outcome



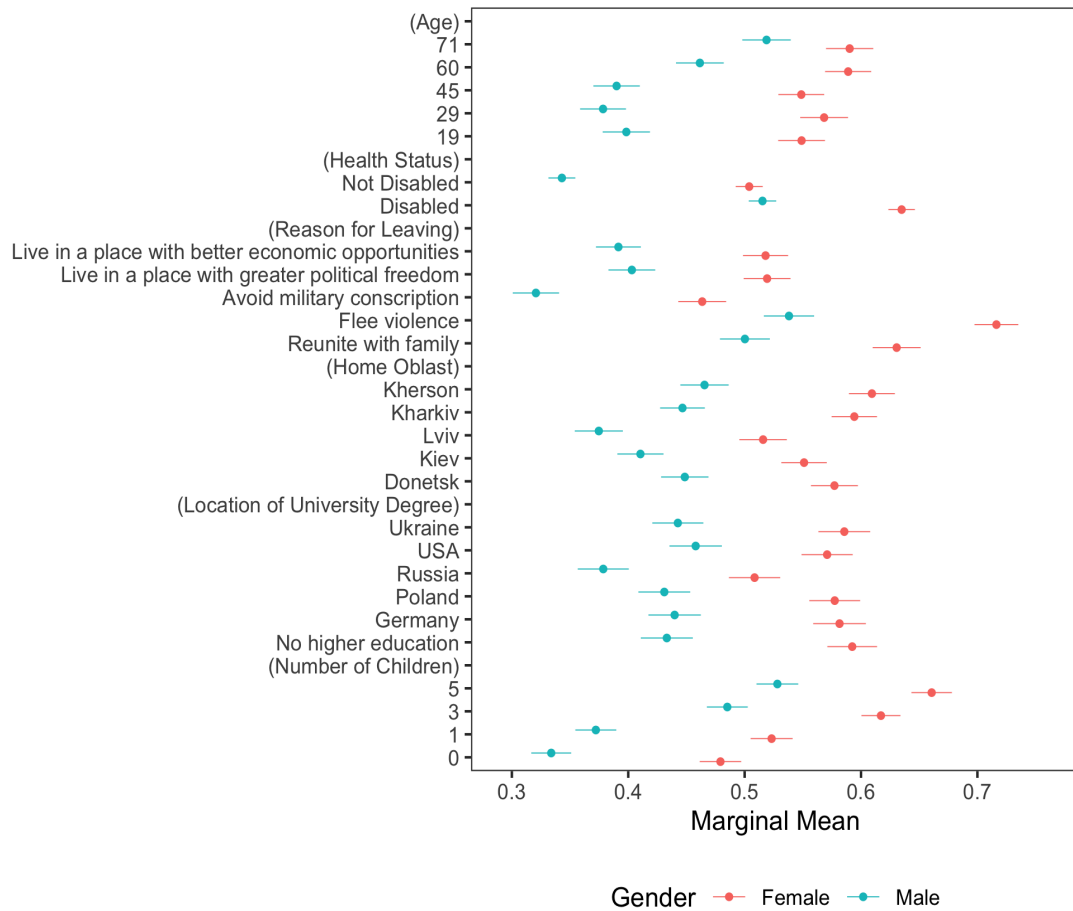
Obr. 2: AMCE (Average Marginal Component Effects) with Rating Outcome: Stop Leave



Obr. 3: Marginal Means with Forced Choice Outcome



Obr. 4: Marginal Means with Rating Outcome: Stop Leave



Obr. 5: Marginal Means with Forced Choice Outcome: Emigrant Gender

Conclusion

This study shows that public judgments of wartime emigration are structured by distinct and predictable moral logics. Citizens do not evaluate departures randomly or emotionally; they rely on heuristics of vulnerability, civic obligation, and merit to assess who deserves to leave. Caregiving profiles and those exposed to violence are viewed with empathy and moral approval, while able-bodied men of conscription age face consistent disapproval, particularly when departing for personal or economic reasons. Profiles marked by education or cosmopolitan traits receive more ambivalent evaluations, indicating that competence alone does not exempt individuals from civic

expectations during national crisis.

Our findings complicate existing accounts of emigration that center on individual choice, economic calculus, or structural drivers. We argue that emigration, especially under conditions of war, is a moral and civic act. Our contribution lies in formalizing a deservingness model that integrates trait-based heuristics with context-specific expectations about duty, solidarity, and symbolic belonging. The model bridges literatures in migration studies, moral psychology, and political theory, offering a framework for understanding how public opinion interprets mobility in moments of collective threat.

The broader implications extend beyond Ukraine. Public judgments of exit are deeply tied to civic cohesion and political order. In wartime, they help sustain the moral meaning of sacrifice and reinforce the boundaries of belonging. As states and societies confront new displacement crises, our findings underscore the need to examine how deservingness is constructed, not only in legal or humanitarian terms, but through shared civic norms that shape democratic responses to emigration under duress. Although contextually specific, our findings from Ukraine clarify how wartime reconfigures public morality and how emigration judgments articulate broader civic expectations and symbolic boundaries of belonging.

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